COLLEGE OF ENGINEERING, UIC

CS 377 Ethical Issues in Computing (3 Credit Hours)

"Evil comes from a failure to think" —Hannah Arendt

Fall 2026

Instructor & Course Details

Course: CS 377 — Ethical Issues in Computing (3 credit hours)

Term: Fall 2026

Class meetings: Mondays and Wednesdays
12:30–1:45pm (for CRN 36199)
2:00–3:15pm (for CRN 38340)

Classroom: CDRLC 2411

Method of instruction: In-person.

Instructor: Jack Bandy (he/him), jxb@uic.edu.

Office: CDRLC 3454

Office phone: (312) 555-0101

Drop-in (office) hours: See Canvas

Teaching assistants:
Abhijith Sreenivasan (asree5@uic.edu)
Sai Samith Reddy Sudini (ssudi4@uic.edu)

Email: jxb@uic.edu. I generally reply within 24 hours on weekdays, and I generally do not check email on Saturday and Sunday. Students are responsible for all messages sent to their UIC email and Canvas accounts.

Course Site

Details and updates about class meetings, office hours, teaching assistants, assignment due dates, and grades will be regularly updated in **Canvas**. Other materials go on the public website whenever possible.

Canvas Course (canvas.uic.edu) - Students are expected to log in to Canvas regularly to upload assignments, monitor grades, and learn about any developments related to the course.

Public Website (doethics.fun) - New this semester! The course now has a public site with reference materials such as slides, assignment descriptions, ethical dilemmas, and more. The site is new and there are still improvements to be made, so you are encouraged to submit fixes/improvements in the Github repository.

Course Information

Catalog Course Description

CS 377. Ethical Issues in Computing. 3 hours.

Official catalog course description: Communication skills for computing professionals: presentation organization, visual aides, delivery techniques, argument support. Ethical and societal issues in computing: privacy, intellectual property and ownership, crime.

Prerequisite: Credit or concurrent registration in CS 251.

Further information: UIC Computer Science course catalog.

Section-Specific Course Description

What does it mean for Computer Scientists to be socially responsible? Billions of people interact with computational systems every day for communication, amusement, work, travel, education, and more. Although many such interactions appear to happen seamlessly, even the most mundane human-computer interaction often has ethical implications (e.g. related to privacy, climate, power, inequality, public health). To explore these ethical implications, this course will survey classical perspectives of ethics (i.e. Deontological Ethics, Utilitarian Ethics, Virtue Ethics, Care Ethics) and practice using them to interpret real-world situations involving humans and computers. Students will explore ethical issues in algorithmic decision-making, data stewardship, user interface design, software engineering, search engines, algorithmic media feeds, large language models, and chatbots, to name some examples. Class sessions will promote active engagement through peer teaching, small group discussions, and other interactive exercises.

Learning Priorities

You may be accustomed to seeing concrete and specific "learning outcomes" for math and CS classes. The outcomes for this class are more nebulous.

Namely, learning ethics is an ongoing practice. This class will therefore encourage you to continue discovering and practicing your own values and your own personal ethical commitments. In your other math and CS classes, you may eventually reach full expertise in a topic area, such as binary arithmetic. But you will not know everything there is to know about ethics just by completing this course.

Still, by the end of the course, you will hopefully be able to do the following:

- analyze events and ethical dilemmas through the four lenses discussed in class: virtue ethics, deontological ethics, utilitarian ethics, and care ethics;
- explain fundamental professional responsibilities related to ethical, legal, security, and social issues in computing, including recurring ethical challenges in computing;
- communicate ethical analyses clearly to different audiences, in writing and in a spoken presentation with visual aids;
- trace hypothetical and real-world ethical issues through various design and engineering decisions (and describe alternative options as needed);
- read a full-length book related to a computing ethics topic and describe what you learned to your peers; and
- articulate and justify your own ethical commitments

Potential topics: Beyond the classical ethical theories (Virtue, Deontological, Utilitarian, and Care Ethics), the course draws on a rotating set of topics, including:

Value-sensitive / culturally-sensitive design	Labor displacement and deskilling
Privacy as contextual integrity	Ethics through speculative fiction and sci-fi
Addiction and "dark patterns" in UI design	Methods for measuring fairness and bias
Economic bubbles and hype cycles in tech	Online safety and content moderation
Bias, discrimination in large language models	Digital rights (to repair, to be forgotten, etc.)
Ethics and emotion in data visualization	Microtargeting and behavioral manipulation
Environmental costs of computing	Facial recognition (privacy and discrimination)
Anonymity and security for data analytics	Monopoly power / the politics of "big tech"
Inequality and the "digital divide"	Algorithmic feeds and their implications
Technology's role in peace, conflict, and war	Intellectual property, licensing, open-sourcing
Dilemmas in cybersecurity	Medical/health technologies

Materials

Readings and other materials will be provided through the course website, web archives, and/or links in the public course website. Materials with copyright restrictions will be distributed through Canvas and/or printed copies. See also "Respect for Copyright" below.

There is no required textbook, however, the course draws heavily from *Computing and Technology Ethics: Engaging through Science Fiction* by Emanuelle Burton, Judy Goldsmith, Nicholas Mattei, Cory Siler, and Sara-Jo Swiatek.

Students will occasionally make their own selections of different research papers, news articles, case studies, books, and/or other materials.

If obtaining any course material presents a challenge for any reason, please tell me as soon as possible.

Respect for Copyright

I try to build this course out of open materials (public domain, Creative Commons, open-access preprints, and things I wrote myself), and usually link them publicly on doethics.fun.

Some materials are not open, and those are distributed only through Canvas. Please protect the integrity of that material: do not upload course materials you did not create to third-party websites, and do not share them with people who are not enrolled in the course. This includes worksheets, rubrics, and any readings posted behind the Canvas login.

Work you create for this course belongs to you. If I would like to reuse something you made — as an example for a future class, or on the course website — I will ask you first, and "no" is a complete answer with no effect on your grade.

Growth Mindset

Once again, unlike many other courses in the Computer Science department, the questions and "problems" discussed in this class often lack verifiable, complete, computable solutions. In many cases, there is no correct answer (maybe not even a general consensus!) to resolve ethical challenges.

For this reason as well as others, you may find course materials and exercises to be uniquely challenging. However, they are crucial to your personal growth and development. They are not intended to trick you or discourage you or make you feel uncomfortable. That being said, there may be times when you need extra help or extra time to process materials in order to reach your own understanding, which is quite normal.

Any student can succeed if they attend class consistently, participate in discussions, complete exercises, thoughtfully engage with feedback (including feedback from the instructor, TAs, and peers), and ask for help when struggling. These habits will help you develop a thorough understanding of the course material and ultimately succeed in the course.

If we are indeed successful, by the end of the course, you will develop an understanding of your own values and the ethical reasoning behind them. This is useful not only for the course, the CS degree, and your future career, but also for your life in general.

Tips for Success

Concretely, "successful" students in this class will:

- review materials (readings, videos, etc.) before class, and write pre-class reflections before class starts
- bring questions to class, sharing them with their table and/or with the whole class
- begin the "read a book" exercise early rather than treating it as an end-of-semester assignment
- come to drop-in hours at least once
- contribute to the GitHub repository at least once
- reach out as early as possible if/when feeling lost or confused about anything

Technology Outside the Classroom

Students will need access to a web browser in order to use Canvas and access materials through the course website. This can be on your own laptop or a campus computer.

Exercises will be submitted and graded in Canvas unless otherwise noted.

Technology in the Classroom

TLDR: no phones, no laptops in class - take notes on paper!

I remember the frustration and shock I felt when I showed up to my first Computer Science course in college and learned that I was not allowed to use my computer. I have slowly realized that this policy was best for me as a student, and in most cases, it remains the best policy for an effective learning environment.

In Summer 2026, I looked at peer-reviewed scientific evidence on the subject of in-class technology usage. As with other times I have explored the evidence, my impression was that **in-class device usage is detrimental for learning**, even when students feel accustomed to multitasking. Individual studies as well as meta-reviews continue to characterize devices in class as fundamentally distracting, with a negative influence on various measures of learning and performance.

Interestingly, while some students can multitask and still comprehend material *during* class time, those students experience significantly reduced *long-term retention* (Glass & Kang, 2019).

For these reasons and others, **by default, all class periods will be free from cell phones, laptops, and tablets**. In some cases we will use devices for activities, usually for a few minutes at the end of class.

This policy is intended for your own benefit as well as the benefit of your classmates, as using a device often has a chain reaction of distracting other students around you.

You will be provided a notebook and/or paper for the course to take notes and write down questions that arise or factoids you wish to research after class. You are always encouraged to ask about factoids that you might otherwise look up on your device - someone in the class might know the answer, or at least have some insight!

Also, if you prefer to take notes on a device that can sit flat on the table, and you are confident that you can do this without distracting yourself and without distracting others, please come see me to make an arrangement.

Finally, **I will revisit the no-phone no-laptop policy with students throughout the semester**, and I remain open to revising the policy based on feedback, student needs, and of course, peer-reviewed evidence.

In case you are curious, here is some of the evidence I looked at during Summer 2026 regarding in-class device distractions:

- Flanigan, Brady, Dai, & Ray (2023). Managing student digital distraction in the college classroom: A self-determination theory perspective. *Educational Psychology Review*. doi.org/10.1007/s10648-023-09780-y
  - "...research has suggested that these digital distractions can negatively impact learning and performance."
- Dontre (2021). The influence of technology on academic distraction: A review. *Human Behavior and Emerging Technologies*. doi.org/10.1002/hbe2.229
  - "The detrimental effects of student smartphone and social media use on academic distraction are more conspicuous, especially with the pervasiveness of personal digital devices."
- Martin, Long, Haywood, & Xie (2025). Digital distractions in education: A systematic review of research on causes, consequences and prevention strategies. *Educational Technology Research and Development*. doi.org/10.1007/s11423-025-10550-6
  - "Consequences for digital distraction included personal performance issues (66.67%), ineffective classroom instruction (23.33%), and problematic technology use (10%)."
- Wang, Tigelaar, Zhou, & Admiraal (2023). The effects of mobile technology usage on cognitive, affective, and behavioural learning outcomes in primary and secondary education: A systematic review with meta-analysis. *Journal of Computer Assisted Learning*. doi.org/10.1111/jcal.12759
  - Notably, this review found that *structured, instructor-directed* technology use can help: "using mobile technology produced medium positive and statistically significant effects on primary and secondary students' learning."
- Sana, Weston, & Cepeda (2013). Laptop multitasking hinders classroom learning for both users and nearby peers. *Computers & Education*. doi.org/10.1016/j.compedu.2012.10.003
  - "...multitasking on a laptop poses a significant distraction to both users and fellow students and can be detrimental to comprehension of lecture content."

Course Policies & Classroom Expectations

Assessment

This class aims to use principles of student-centered teaching, also referred to as "non-directive teaching," which de-emphasizes quantitative grading. This teaching style focuses on open-ended dialogue, project-based learning, and student curiosity, rather than regurgitation and examinations.

Still, in order to provide a final letter grade at the end of the class, I will use the following combination of graded exercises:

Category	Weight
Out-of-class exercises	**20%**
Food in your feed	
Online account biopsy	
Online account scrap doll	
Speculative fiction	
Fairness definition	
Personal ethical commitment	
"Read a Book" project	**20%**
Book selection and justification	
2-page book report or un-essay	
Peer instruction / book presentation	
Actually reading the book	
Pre-class reflections	**20%**
Expect about one per week	
Attendance, participation, and civility	**20%**
Tracked in Canvas	
In-class group exercises	**19%**
Expect about one per week	
The button	**1%**
Details TBA	

Further details and rubrics for each exercise will be published on Canvas.

Grading Scale

You can expect the following correspondence between your percentage grade in the course and your final letter grade, and the "equivalent" description from the registrar's grading system.

F	D	C	B	A
59% or below	60–69%	70–79%	80–89%	90–100%
Failure	Poor but passing	Average	Good	Excellent

Student Accountability for Coursework

Detailed instructions and a rubric for every exercise will be posted on Canvas, usually at least one week before the work is due. If an exercise is still being developed, its Canvas page will say so, and I will announce it in class once it is ready.

Unless an exercise says otherwise:

- Out-of-class exercises and pre-class reflections are submitted in Canvas by the posted due date.
- In-class group exercises are completed and turned in on paper during class
  - another reason why attendance matters.
- "Read a Book" milestones (selection, report, presentation) each have their own due date, spread across the semester

If you miss an in-class group exercise, tell me as soon as you can. Makeups are not guaranteed because some exercises only work with a group in the room, however, some can be made up in some form so it is worth asking.

See "Feedback, Revisions, and Regrading" below for when to expect feedback and how to request a revision or regrade.

Midterm Grades

Grades in Canvas are kept current throughout the semester, so you can check where you stand at any point.

Around the midpoint of the semester I will also do a check-in: if your grade or attendance suggests you are at risk of not passing, I will email you directly so we have time to intervene. You are always welcome to come to drop-in hours to ask about your grade.

Tests and Final Exams

There will be no tests or examinations in this class. I agree with Carl Rogers[1] that life itself offers enough examinations, and I hope that what you learn in this class will help you meet life's tests with more confidence and satisfaction. See above for details regarding your final grade.

There is no final exam in this course, and no meeting will be scheduled during the university's final examination period. Check Canvas for due dates at the end of the semester.

Attendance and Participation

Showing up makes a substantial difference in this course (and in life). Many class meetings are intentionally designed around table discussions and group work, so students are expected to attend, arrive on time, and participate.

Please notify the instructor as soon as possible when illness, personal emergencies, university obligations, religious observances, or other circumstances may prevent attendance. Note that this is also a courtesy to the community, as unexpected absences and late arrivals can be disruptive to everyone in class.

I take attendance each class. Four absences may be taken without penalty, and they do not have to be explicitly excused. If a student misses more than four classes without notifying the instructor, the instructor will reach out to them, and reserves the right to lower the "Attendance, Participation,

[1] *On Becoming a Person*, Chapter 14

and Civility" portion of the overall grade.

Generally, if you miss a fifth class without notifying the instructor, your "Attendance, Participation, and Civility" grade will be lowered from 20/20 to 18/20. Additional deductions (i.e. two points per unexcused absence) will be noted in Canvas.

Separately, and regardless of points earned in other categories, students who miss more than half of all class sessions will not be able to pass the course. I hope we will not have to get into the specific metrics and rounding schemes - again, I will reach out if your attendance becomes an issue.

Asynchronous sessions: A small number of sessions are asynchronous rather than in-person (currently October 5 and October 7 — see the schedule below). There is no class meeting on those days. Work posted in Canvas takes the place of both attendance and the in-class exercise, and completing it by the posted deadline counts as attending.

Attendance-related accommodations: If you have a Letter of Accommodation from the Disability Resource Center that includes accommodations around attendance, those accommodations take precedence. Please share your LOA with me as soon as possible and we will work out how the accommodations apply to this course.

Student-athletes: UIC has an official missed class time policy under which student-athletes provide formal documentation for class time missed due to NCAA or institutionally sanctioned events. Student Athlete Academic Services (SAAS) will provide you with that documentation; please bring it to me as early as you can.

Late Work

Due dates will be listed in Canvas, and there is an automatic "sliding scale" that will deduct points based on how late you submitted the work, down to 50%.

Anything submitted more than one week after the original due date will only receive 50% credit.

If you anticipate any difficulty meeting a due date, contact the instructor as soon as possible. I am often able to adjust due dates, especially if multiple people want/need an extension.

Feedback, Revisions, and Regrading

I aim to return feedback on each exercise within about one week of its due date, give or take. Feel free to ask me if it gets later than that.

Opportunities to revise an exercise are specific to that exercise, as is the process for requesting a regrade. Both will be described in the instructions and rubric for the exercise on Canvas. If you believe an exercise was graded in error, contact the instructor as soon as possible (I prefer to avoid end-of-semester panic sessions).

Academic Integrity and Assurance of Learning

UIC is an academic community committed to providing an environment in which research, learning, and scholarship can flourish and in which all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity. In this community, all members including faculty, administrators, staff, and students alike share the responsibility to uphold the highest standards of academic honesty and quality of academic work so that such a collegial and productive environment exists.

Students are expected to follow UIC's Community Standards and policies on academic integrity.

See also the UIC Student Disciplinary Policy, which describes how instances of academic misconduct are handled. Unacceptable behavior includes cheating, unauthorized collaboration, fabrication or falsification, plagiarism, multiple submissions without instructor permission, using unauthorized study aids, coercion regarding grading or evaluation of coursework, and facilitating academic misconduct.

By submitting your assignments for grading you acknowledge these terms, you declare that your work is solely your own, and you promise that, unless authorized by the instructor or proctor, you have not communicated with anyone in any way during an exam or other online assessment.

Academic integrity also includes respecting the copyright of course materials — see "Respect for Copyright" above.

In line with UIC's mission to provide "an environment in which research, learning, and scholarship can flourish and in which all endeavors are guided by academic and professional integrity," **the work you turn in for this class must be your own work**.

This is to ensure that **you** develop skills and knowledge from this course that will be valuable to you in your future courses, your career, and other areas of your life. In other words, the point is to **assure that you are learning** so that UIC fulfills its educational mission.

This does not mean that you need to complete all work in a personal Faraday cage. Rather, you are encouraged to discuss your ideas with friends and classmates, and to explore related work (i.e. academic papers, blogs, video essays, forums, etc.). An important part of scholarship is standing on the shoulders of giants,[2] (after all, we are in the City of the Big Shoulders[3]) and acknowledging whose shoulders we stand upon.

In other words, **always cite your sources**!

Please ask the instructor if you need clarity about academic integrity for specific exercises. When in doubt, it is always better to check.

I will reach out to you personally before submitting a report of academic misconduct.

Adapted from the UIC CATE syllabus template.

Use of Generative AI/LLMs

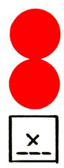
Of particular interest as of August 2026 is the use of LLM-based tools and their implications for academic integrity (i.e. ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, etc.). I am intentionally setting up many exercises this semester to be in-class, on-paper, in-person, etc., to reduce the possibility of using such tools for class exercises.

For individual exercise policies, this course uses CTA rail signals. Every exercise on Canvas will have a signal in the description/rubric.

[2] Ironically, while this phrase is often attributed to Isaac Newton in a letter from 1676, it was first recorded in John of Salisbury's book *Metalogicon* from 1159. I learned this from a blog post on BookBrowse.com

[3] Sandburg, Carl. "Chicago." *Poetry* (March 1914).

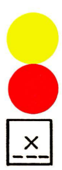
Double red — "stop and stay"



Stop and Stay (Where no Towerman is on duty and signal fails to clear within 60 seconds, call Line Supervisor for instructions.)

No use of AI/LLM-based tools. This is the default for the course, and it covers all in-class work, all pre-class reflections, and the "read the book" exercises.

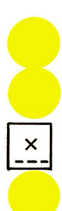
Yellow over red — "proceed with caution, prepared to stop"



Proceed with caution on main route, prepared to stop at next signal.

Limited, optional, specific use; use cautiously, with citation. Certain exercises will offer a narrow set of tasks where LLM-based tools are permitted but not required. This will usually guide you to scrutinize, evaluate, and/or critique the system in some way.

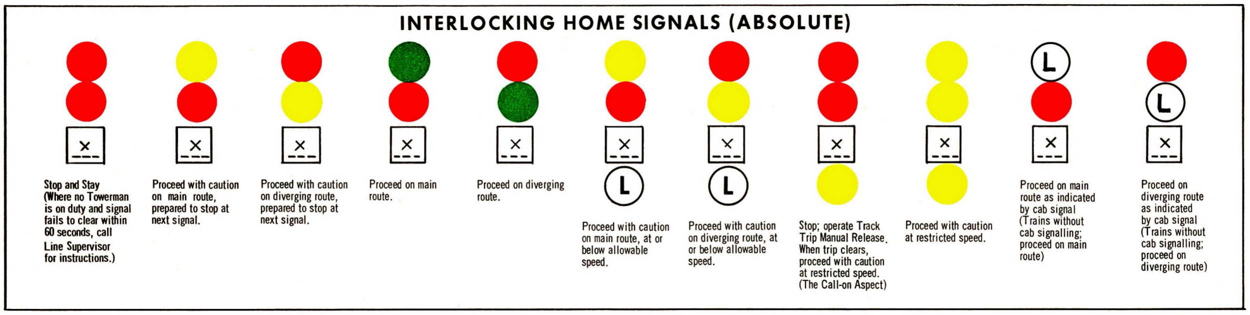
Double yellow — "proceed at restricted speed"



Proceed with caution at restricted speed.

You choose how to use it; use cautiously, with citation. A small number of later exercises may give the judgment call entirely to you. This seems to be how the real world works, so it's good to get some practice.

Just for fun, here is the full set of eleven signals from the 1973 CTA rulebook:



The eleven interlocking home signal aspects from the 1973 CTA rulebook.

Citing your use of AI/LLMs

Whenever the signal is yellow-over-red or double yellow, if you do use an AI/LLM-based tool, include a citation:

> I used [tool and version] to [what you asked it to do]. My prompt was: [prompt, or a summary if it was long]. Here is what I did with the output: [what you kept, changed, or threw away].

This policy is my current best judgment as of August 2026, and it will keep evolving, maybe even during this semester. I am genuinely curious about evidence-based arguments for various different policies - if you see them, bring them to class so we can discuss!

Visitors

This class may welcome visitors (i.e. prospective students, guest speakers, etc.) during the semester. When possible, students will be notified in advance of guest attendance.

Privacy Note on Recording in Class

As of right now I do not plan to record class sessions this semester. If this changes, I will ask for your permission to record, and it will most likely be only audio of mini-lectures.

Privacy is especially important in a discussion-based class, as recording can discourage open conversation and participation. Our class will be more engaging for everyone if more people can freely participate without worrying about being recorded.

So, please do not record any video or audio from class without permission.

FERPA

Federal law (the Family Educational Rights and Privacy Act) prohibits me from disclosing or discussing your grades over email. Please come see me during office hours if you want to talk about your work. I will work with TAs to try to keep grades updated in Canvas, so you can easily see how you are performing in class.

Approximate Course Schedule

The most current schedule will be published on the "do ethics" website. Readings, activities, and due dates may be revised as course needs develop — see "Disclaimer" below.

University deadlines for adding, dropping, and withdrawing from courses are listed on the UIC Academic Calendar.

Week	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
1	Warm-up: Conocimiento; Introduction to Virtue Ethics	
2	Introduction to Deontological Ethics; Introduction to Utilitarian Ethics	
3	Labor Day holiday. **No classes.**; Introduction to Care Ethics	
4	Review theories of ethics; Ethics in Algorithmic Feeds	
5	Algorithmic Feeds and Content Moderation, Continued; Intro to Privacy; Preview short story ("Here and Now"); Privacy, Continued	
6	Privacy, Continued; Discuss short story ("Here and Now"); Preview short story ("Message in a Bottle"); Inequality and Justice; Discuss short story ("Message in a Bottle"); Preview short story ("Codename Delphi")	
7	**Asynchronous class.** Dr. Bandy away.; Inequality and Justice, Continued; Faces and Fairness; Computing and War; Discuss short story ("Codename Delphi"); Preview short story ("If an Algorithm Can Cast a Shadow")	
8	Medical and health technologies; Intro to CyberSecurity; Intro to Ethical Challenges from LLMs; Discuss Speculative Fiction Exercise	
9	Ethical Challenges from LLMs, Continued; Discuss short story ("If an Algorithm Can Cast a Shadow"); Intellectual property	
10	Intellectual property; "Hooks" and "Nudges" in Design; Presentation Tips	
11	Book Presentations; Overview of Fairness Definitions Exercise	
12	Book Presentations	
13	Book Presentations	
14	Book Presentations; Student Wellness Day. **No classes.**	

Week	Topic(s) / In-Class Activities	Readings / Work Due
15	Synthesis and conclusions	

Disclaimer

This syllabus is intended to give the student guidance on what may be covered during the semester and will be followed as closely as possible. However, we might decide to alter this syllabus as course needs arise, and I will communicate such changes through in-class announcements and in writing via Canvas and/or email.

Accommodations

Disability Accommodation Procedures

UIC is committed to full inclusion and participation of people with disabilities. Students who face or anticipate disability-related barriers should contact the Disability Resource Center at `drc@uic.edu` or (312) 413-2183 to create a plan for reasonable accommodations.

To receive accommodations, you will need to disclose the disability to the DRC, complete an interactive registration process with the DRC, and provide me with a Letter of Accommodation (LOA). Letters of Accommodation can be presented at any point in the semester and, unless otherwise noted, do not expire once obtained. Upon receipt of an LOA, I will gladly work with you and the DRC to implement approved accommodations.

Religious Accommodations

I will make every effort to avoid requiring that work be submitted on religious holidays. Students seeking religious accommodations should notify the instructor by the tenth day of the semester, or at least five days in advance when the observance occurs earlier. Please email me with the subject heading "YOUR NAME: Requesting Religious Accommodation" and the date(s) you will be absent. You do not need to supply any verification of your attendance at religious services.

I will make every reasonable effort to honor your request and not penalize you for missing class. If an assignment is due during your absence, you will be given an assignment equivalent to the one completed by students in attendance. Students may appeal through campus grievance procedures for religious accommodations.

Classroom Environment

Classroom Community

The mission statement at my elementary school[4] was "to provide a safe learning environment where every child can reach full potential and bring about positive change in our world." Lofty as it is, I find it to be a meaningful statement that aligns with UIC's official mission statement: "to provide the broadest access to the highest levels of educational, research, and clinical excellence."

[4]This was Wilmore Elementary School in Jessamine County, Kentucky. Our principal Andrea McNeal wrote the mission statement.

You can help UIC work toward this mission by contributing to a respectful, welcoming, and inclusive environment for every member of our class. If aspects of this course result in barriers to your inclusion, engagement, accurate assessment, or achievement, please notify me as soon as possible.

Assume goodwill, listen carefully, debate ideas rather than people, respect privacy, and remain open to revising your position.

Feedback on the Course

In my view, being an effective educator is a life-long journey, meaning I still have a lot to learn in order to do my job effectively. There will be structured opportunities for feedback throughout the course, but please do reach out directly with any additional feedback, questions, ideas, and/or suggestions about how the course might be improved.

At the end of the term you will also be asked to complete UIC's official course evaluation through the Student Evaluation of Teaching program. Responses are anonymous and I do not see them until after final grades are submitted. These evaluations play a real role in how courses get revised, so please take them seriously — though note that they arrive too late to change anything for *your* semester, which is exactly why I also ask for feedback while the course is still running.

Preferred Names and Pronouns

If your name or pronouns do not match the class roster, please let the class know so that we can address you the way you want to be addressed. I use he/him pronouns. For more information, see: `https://www.mypronouns.org/what-and-why`.

Community Agreement

We will build our community agreement together in class (week 2, day 1), and post the version we agree on in Canvas.

Guidelines for Participation and Classroom Conduct

Active participation is one of the most important ways you will learn in this course. I am very aware that participation looks a little different for everyone, and will evaluate your participation accordingly. Still, in general, an engaged student will:

- come to class prepared, for example, by having completed pre-class reflections
- contribute regularly to class activities and discussions
- stay on-task during class
- listen attentively to peers (no side conversations or unnecessary disruptions)
- have an open mind and seek to understand (not judge and make assumptions)
- be gracious and open to change in their ideas, arguments, and positions
- assume goodwill in all interactions, even in disagreement
- complete their work in a timely manner
- reach out to the instructor if they start to fall behind

Content Notices

This is a 300-level University course; as such, we will aim to discuss topics with maturity, dignity, humanity, rigor, and respect for scholarly inquiry.

Some course materials address war, discrimination, surveillance, sex, violence, and related subjects which may be distressing. Please know that the goal is never to cause distress, but to meaningfully engage with real-world issues.

Our classroom provides a space for civil exchange of ideas, which intentionally includes a variety of perspectives and positions. Some readings and other content may expose you to ideas, subjects, or views that may challenge you, cause you discomfort, or recall past negative experiences or traumas. I try to include content notices whenever appropriate. If you have suggested changes (i.e. if there is a place where you recommend adding a content notice), or you would like me to be aware of a specific topic of concern, please email or visit me during office hours.

Resources: Academic Success, Wellness, and Safety

Student Wellbeing

As a student at UIC, I hope you have come to enjoy the learning process and the life of the mind, and I hope you enjoy this particular course. I also understand that life as a college student can sometimes become distressing and overwhelming, which can make it difficult to engage in class.

So, to help you succeed in this course (and in life), I encourage you to proactively care for your body and mind. If you are struggling or anticipate any trouble attending class or turning in assignments on time, **please let me know as early as possible** and I will do whatever I can to help you prioritize your wellbeing.

Below are some of the many support services and resources available to all UIC students:

- Current Student Resources – a one-stop shop for links to resources in the following categories: General, Academic, Student Support, Student Life, Technology, Health and Safety, and Getting Around Campus
- UIC Tutoring Resources
- **Engineering Learning Center (ELC)** – peer tutoring for required engineering courses, led by students who have already succeeded in them. Located in SELE NE2063 (950 S. Halsted), in person and online.
- Academic success programming for first-generation students: the College of Engineering runs EIEP FIRST GEN (faculty connections, dialogue events, community building, and career development), and campus-wide, TRIO Student Support Services offers academic coaching, tutoring, and career/graduate school advising to students who are first-generation, from low-income families, and/or have documented disabilities.
- Programs and initiatives supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs through the Student Success Initiative
- If you are experiencing personal hardships (e.g. personal and family emergencies, academics, interpersonal conflicts, personal safety, physical and mental health concerns, food or housing insecurity) and need resources and assistance, please reach out to the Student Assistance division, supported by UIC's Office of the Dean of Students
- Student Guide for Information Technology – a comprehensive resource for UIC students describing the most commonly used IT services and tools supporting your success
- Navigating Health Resources at UIC – explore the many resources that are on campus to support students' health and wellbeing and learn about how you can access them.

Importantly, **if you are in immediate distress**, please know the UIC Counseling Center provides high-quality crisis intervention services, available 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. You can walk into the Counseling Center during business hours to request to talk to a crisis counselor, or you can call the Counseling Center main line at (312) 996-3490. If you are calling outside of business hours, select "2" during the automated greeting to be connected to a crisis counselor. You can find additional mental health resources and services on the Counseling Center website and in the Student's Guide to Accessing Behavioral Health Services at UIC.

For immediate crisis support outside of UIC, call or text "9-8-8" any time, 24 hours a day, 7 days a week. Dialing 988 will connect you to a trained crisis professional. 988 offers services in Spanish, American Sign Language, and over 240 languages through tele-interpretation services. The 988 website has an online chat feature, too.

We all need the help and the support of our UIC community. Please visit drop-in hours for course consultation and other academic or research topics. For additional assistance, please contact your assigned college advisor and visit the support services available to all UIC students.

Academic Success

- **Equity and Inclusion in Engineering Program (EIEP)** – tutoring, study space, career advising, summer programs, support for affinity-based engineering student organizations, and resources for undocumented students.
- **UIC Library** – locations on east and west campus, with research support in person or online via chat. Stop by the reference desk in the IDEA Commons at Daley Library, make an appointment for research help, or consult the subject-specific Research Guides.
- **Academic Center for Excellence (ACE)** – individualized help with reading, writing, study skills, and time management. Call (312) 413-0031.
- Academic advising and the offices supporting the UIC undergraduate experience and academic programs

Wellness

- **U&I Care Program** – assistance for students facing personal hardships, including emergency funds and referrals
- **UIC Counseling Center** – free, confidential intake with a trained therapist for students who pay the student health services fee, leading to brief individual or group therapy, psychiatry referrals, or care coordination with a community provider. Located in the Student Services Building; call (312) 996-3490 during business hours. (See above for 24/7 crisis intervention.)
- **Campus Advocacy Network** – confidential victim services and advocacy under Title IX, which gives you the right to an education free from gender-based violence and discrimination, including sexual assault, domestic violence, harassment, and stalking. Call 312-413-8206. To make a report to UIC's Title IX office, email `TitleIX@uic.edu` or call (312) 996-8670.

Safety

- **UIC SAFE App** (link to download) – a free personal security tool that puts you in easy contact with dispatchers and first responders in an emergency
- UIC Safety Resources and the UIC Police – safety tips, alerts, and campus security programs
- **Walking Safety Escort and Night Ride** – use either if you are uncomfortable traveling

anywhere on campus. You are discouraged from staying in university buildings alone, including lab rooms, after hours.

- **Emergency response guides** – from the Office of Preparedness and Response. Please review the recommendations for various emergency situations.
- Emergency: Dial 5-5555 from a campus phone, or (312) 355-5555 from a cell phone

Support for Parenting Students

Balancing school, childcare, and work can be difficult. If you are a parenting student, you can tell me so we can plan around it. Occasionally bringing a child to class to cover an unexpected gap in care is perfectly acceptable, and you can sit near the door so you can step out if you need to.

UIC supports parenting students by providing affordable, high-quality childcare for infants, toddlers, and young children, along with a comprehensive wraparound care system, study-play areas across campus, accessible lactation rooms, year-round family events, and more. For more information, contact Melinda Young (`mmcghe2@uic.edu`) or visit the Little Sparks website.

Tutoring and Academic Support Centers

The Writing Center offers friendly and supportive tutors who can help you with reading and writing in any of your courses, not just English. Tutors are ready to help with other writing as well, such as job applications, personal statements, and resumes. The tutor and you will work together to decide how to improve your writing. If you have not started your assignment, that is OK. A tutor can help you brainstorm or make an outline. Tutors understand that you might be using the Writing Center for the first time. They are ready to guide you through your first session. You can choose to work with a tutor in person or in real time over the internet using video, audio, or chat and a whiteboard. For more information and to schedule an appointment, visit the Writing Center website.

The Math and Science Learning Center, located in the Science and Engineering South Building (SES) at 845 W. Taylor St. 3rd Floor, Room 247, is a meeting place for students in Math, Biological Sciences, Chemistry, Earth and Environmental Sciences, and Physics. At the MSLC, students can meet with graduate teaching assistants for tutoring in 100-level courses, attend informal group study sessions with other students, or meet up with friends to attend one of the workshops, seminars, or other activities sponsored by the MSLC during the semester. Visit the MSLC website, call 312-355-4900, or email at `mslc@uic.edu`.

The Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) can help if you feel you need more individualized instruction in reading and/or writing, study skills, time management, etc. Please call (312) 413-0031 or visit the Academic Center for Excellence (ACE) website for more information.

Health Services

Student Health Services are available if you get sick during the semester. The Family Medicine Center is committed to providing high-quality, student centered care and services. It has attending physicians, residents, and nurse practitioners on staff to provide the full range of primary health care services. The Family Medicine Center also offers a limited set of health services at no additional cost to students who pay the Student Health Service Fee (SHSF). Services include caring for an acute or urgent illness (e.g., cold, strep throat, asthma attack, flu) or an injury. More information can be found on the Family Medicine Center's Student Health webpage.

A Closing Note

Lastly, here is a picture of Hannah Arendt. She said that "evil comes from a failure to think." If we are successful in this class, we will do some real thinking, and perhaps even prevent some evil.

Hannah Arendt, photographed on New Year's Day, 1944. © Fred Stein/dpa/Corbis

Parts of this syllabus were copied or lightly modified from the syllabus template published by UIC's Center for the Advancement of Teaching Excellence (CATE), available at https://teaching.uic.edu/cate-teaching-guides/syllabus-course-design/syllabus/.